

PARTY SLOGAN

**SOCIAL JUSTICE
IN PRACTICE
IS OUR ULTIMATE GOAL**

59

is the number of
defectors the PRP
has fielded, the
highest for any
party in the
country.

Rs 100. Essentially, his electoral mantra is social and economic justice for the disadvantaged leading to a prosperous, content state.

Now, the bad news. His rivals, Naidu and incumbent chief minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, have offered their own populist packages. More importantly, Chitranjeevi's political naïveté has led to a growing number of detractors accusing him of allowing the PRP to be run like a film production company amid allegations of crores of rupees having changed hands before contestants could collect a PRP ticket. Further, his brother-in-law Allu Arvind is accused of back seat driving. There have been other sordid episodes that have exposed the discontent, dissension and even desertion in the PRP ranks which has badly damaged the star's reputation as an off-screen do-gooder, not to mention his party's electoral chances.

What that means is that the real electoral strength of the PRP remains an unknown factor though it is clear that the initial hysteria has abated and Chiru's rail engine has started to run out of steam. He himself seems reconciled to playing the role of kingmaker rather than king this time around. With Reddy and Naidu likely to fall short of gaining a majority on their own, they will need the PRP's support. This means that the 'Chiru Factor' can still play a crucial role after the votes are counted. If that does happen, he is likely to insist that his populist schemes be implemented. It also means that his influence could spread beyond Hyderabad with the PRP participating in the multi-party formation sponsored by the Yadavs across Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Jharkand, and Bihar. Viewed in that context, the PRP for want of sufficient strength may support a Congress government in Andhra Pradesh and strike a bargain to be part of the coalition ministry making in Delhi. In that sense, the script for his political avatar has been written and the camera has just begun to roll. **by Amarnath K. Menon**

A. PRABHAKAR RAO

Losing STEAM

Chiranjeevi wants to be king but could well end up as kingmaker with no single party likely to sweep the polls

Chiranjeevi is to Andhra Pradesh what Shah Rukh Khan is to Bollywood. From the time the latest aspirant for the post of chief minister plunged into the electoral fray, massive crowds have been going hysterical at his rallies. The south has a history of backing film stars for political roles, the most obvious example being former chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu's late father-in-law, N.T. Rama Rao. Chiranjeevi, better known as Chiru, is projecting himself as a champion of

the backward classes and promises to grant scholarships to children from disadvantaged groups, subsidised education and a Rs 5,000-crore corpus from which the State Backward Classes Finance Corporation can loan money to girls to enhance their economic prospects. He has also pledged to create 10 lakh jobs for the youth within 1,000 days of assuming office and a monthly grocery package for the poor that includes 25 kg of rice, one kg each of sugar, cooking oil and dal and half a kilo of tamarind for

No one can stop the silent revolution to bring the PRP to power and change the state's history with votes.

CHIRANJEEVI, PRP CHIEF